ASKED ABOUT THE FUTURE OF BANGLADESH-CHINA TIES, RAHMAN SAID HE WON'T SUPPORT ANYTHING THAT'S NOT IN BANGLADESH'S FAVOUR

political research organisation and think-tank based in Bangladesh. That said, Pranay Kumar Verma, the Indian High Commissioner to Dhaka, met JeI head and leader of Opposition Dr Shafiqur Rahman on February 17.

Another concern is Dhaka's growing proximity with Islamabad and Beijing. India had expressed concern when the Yunus regime re-established ties with Pakistan and pushed for connectivity and trade. China already has high stakes in Bangladesh, having committed projects worth $40 billion as part of its Belt and Road Initiative (BRI). Even Hasina courted Beijing, taking its help to build a prime naval base, ostensibly to train the Bangladesh Navy, but which India saw as facilitating the berthing of Chinese submarines.

At a press conference on February 14, a day after Modi's phone call, a Chinese journalist asked Rahman about the future of Bangladesh-China relations. His response was measured. He said that if something was not "in interest, in favour of Bangladesh", his government would not support it. On BRI projects in Bangladesh, he said his government would assess whether they genuinely helped Bangladesh's economy before taking a decision. India will be watching how he proceeds on these fronts.

TIC DILEMMA



ANI

Sheikh Hasina with PM Modi, June 2024

FOR NEW DELHI, THE MOST VIABLE PATH FORWARD APPEARS TO LIE NOT IN DRAMATIC GESTURES BUT IN CALIBRATED RESTRAINT

the diplomatic puzzle.

For the new Bangladesh Nationalist Party (BNP) government, her physical presence in India is uncomfortable but manageable. What has proved politically combustible is her continued activism. From Indian soil, Hasina has addressed supporters on social media, spoken to domestic and international media, and cast herself as the legitimate leader of a wronged political order. To many in Bangladesh, this creates the impression—intentional or otherwise—that India is enabling political interference.

New Delhi's dilemma is, therefore, unusually acute. Extraditing her would establish a precedent the Indian state has historically avoided, particularly in cases involving capital punishment. Yet permitting unrestricted political engagement risks souring relations with a democratically elected government in Dhaka and reinforcing the long-standing perception that India plays favourites in Bangladesh's politics.

The most viable path forward appears to lie not in dramatic gestures but in calibrated restraint. Indian officials have already indicated that Hasina is unlikely to be allowed to use Indian territory for overt political mobilisation. Limiting media access, discouraging public statements and framing her stay strictly on humanitarian grounds could give New Delhi space to argue that it is not intervening in Bangladesh's domestic affairs.

For the BNP leadership, this may suffice—for now. As Mirza Fakhrul Islam Alamgir, the party's secretary general and a senior minister, has suggested, extradition need not be an immediate precondition for engagement. What matters is preventing Hasina from becoming a running sore in bilateral ties. ■

—ADM